

in terms of time, money, health, or variety. At this point, the site searches through recipes that match your needs, prices out the cost of the meal for you, and lets you print out your shopping list.⁶

Clearly, this is an elaborate service. Behind the scenes, a team of professional chefs devise recipes that take advantage of items that are on sale at local grocery stores around the country. Those recipes are matched via computer algorithm to each family's unique needs and preferences. Try to visualize the work involved: databases of almost every grocery store in the country must be maintained, including what's on sale at each one this week. Those groceries have to be matched to appropriate recipes and then appropriately customized, tagged, and sorted. If a recipe calls for broccoli rabe, is that the same ingredient as the broccoli on sale at the local market?

After reading that description, you might be surprised to learn that Food on the Table (FotT) began life with a single customer. Instead of supporting thousands of grocery stores around the country as it does today, FotT supported just one. How did the company choose which store to support? The founders didn't—until they had their first customer. Similarly, they began life with no recipes whatsoever—until their first customer was ready to begin her meal planning. In fact, the company served its first customer without building any software, without signing any business development partnerships, and without hiring any chefs.

Manuel, along with VP of product Steve Sanderson, went to local supermarkets and moms' groups in his hometown of Austin. Part of their mission was the typical observation of customers that is a part of design thinking and other ideation techniques. However, Manuel and his team were also on the hunt for something else: their first customer.

As they met potential customers in those settings, they would interview them the way any good market researcher would, but at the end of each interview they would attempt to make a sale. They'd describe the benefits of FotT, name a weekly subscription fee, and invite the customer to sign up. Most times they were rejected. After all, most people are not early adopters and will not